changeless, unified and eternal substance or Soul (***atman***). Thoughts, sensations, emotions and actions undoubtedly occur but this should not be interpreted as implying the existence of a constant subject as a further fact over and above the stream of experiences. Belief in one's own identity is a form of selfish clinging that leads to suffering and anxiety. Early Buddhism reduces individual personality to a stream of five causally interdependent and ever-changing psycho-physical components (***skandhas***); matter, feelings, perceptions, dispositions and thoughts which neither collectively nor singly amount to an enduring substantial self or soul.

As the tradition developed, the cosmos was understood as a basically impersonal process of events rather than as the interaction of persisting entities. It is a misconception, arising from human convenience, that there really are any enduring entities, including selves. Whatever is conventionally considered as a stable continuant is reductively analysed as a stream of occurrences, a flux of impersonal physical and mental atomic factors. This implies that there is no real distinction between enduring substrates and their properties. What makes for the continuity of a person's life is just the occurrence of a series of suitably interconnected physical and mental factors. Such a series constructs an awareness of itself as a persisting centre of experience and agency. This fabrication becomes selfish, alienated from others and protective of its own interests that it anxiously promotes.

Further reading: Collins 1982; Gethin 1998; Rahula 1969; Siderits 2003

Anavastha (infinite regress): this is not technically a logical fallacy, but it indicates that a particular argument can never be proved. Cases include the claim that a cognitive state needs to be the object of another cognitive state before the subject knows that he is in it; that the truth